12. The Siege of Purandar and the Treaty with the Moghul Emperor

Raid on Surat : After this triumph, Shivaji did not sit idle. Aurangzeb's troops were laying waste the whole of Maharashtra. To bring the Emperor to his senses, Shivaji carried out his daring raid on Surat. Surat was so far away from Pune that no one but Shivaji could have thought of this daring raid. Surat was then a great centre of trade in the Moghul empire and a very rich city. Shivaji carried out the raid successfully and brought home a booty worth lakhs of rupees. Shivaji did not forsake ethics in the raid on Surat. He spared the churches and mosques. He did not show disrespect to women.

The raid on Surat drove Aurangzeb into a furious rage. He now decided to put an end to the Maratha Kingdom. He ordered his great general, Mirza Raje Jaising, to humble Shivaji. To assist Mirza Raje in the campaign, he sent with him his trusted Sardar, Dilerkhan. The two landed in the Deccan with a huge army and unlimited funds. Swaraj was in real danger.

Immediately after his return from the expedition of Surat, in 1664 AD, Shivaji Maharaj heard a sad news. Shahaji Raje had suffered an accidental death while on



Fort Purandar

a hunt. Shivaji and Jijabai were greatly grieved. Holding his mother close to his bosom, Shivaji Maharaj consoled her.

Siege of Purandar by the Moghul Army : Purandar was one of Shivaji's big and strong forts. Dilerkhan knew that Shivaji could not be defeated as long as he was the master of Purandar. He, therefore, laid siege to this powerful fort. He had a huge army under his command. Murarbaji was in charge of the fort. He was a determined fighter who would not easily yield to threats. He was also supported by brave troops. With their help Murarbaji decided to defend the fort.

Dilerkhan's guns went into action. Fiery cannon balls began to drop on the fort. Murarbaji and his brave men held on. The first bastion on the 'Machi' collapsed under gun-fire. Dilerkhan's troops captured the lower fort. The Marathas withdrew to the upper fort and continued to fight. Dilerkhan was watching the battle from his camp.

Furious with rage, Murarbaji decided to attack the Moghul troops with a select contingent of five hundred men. He opened the gates of the upper fort. Shouting their war cry, "Har Har Mahadeo," the Mavlas fell on the Moghul troops. After a fierce battle which lasted for a short time, the Marathas routed the huge Moghul army which fled towards Dilerkhan's camp.

Murarbaji followed them in hot pursuit. With his troops he entered the camp of Dilerkhan and wrought havoc there. The enemy troops were in flight and the Marathas in pursuit. Cries and shouts filled the whole camp. In great hurry Dilerkhan mounted his elephant and looked ahead. There was Murarbaji hacking the soldiers to pieces. His sword moved like lightning, cut throats, broke heads and pierced the hearts of the enemy. No one could stop him or hold him in check. Dilerkhan watched in admiration his great deeds of bravery.

Murarbaji's Incomparable Valour : Seeing Dilerkhan, Murarbaji asked his troops to attack in full force and himself advanced towards Dilerkhan. Whoever tried to obstruct him was cut to pieces. The Moghul troops at last surrounded Murarbaji on all sides. Just then Dilerkhan shouted, "Wait ; Hold back your swords !" The Moghul troops halted and moved back a little. Then Dilerkhan addressed Murarbaji, "Until now I have not seen a swordsman like you. You come over to our side. I promise you complete safety. The Emperor will make you a Sardar, and reward you with a Jagir". His eyes red with anger, Murarbaji said in return, "We are the loyal servants of Shivaji Maharaj. Who wants to buy safety from you ? Why should we come over to your side ? And who wants your Emperor's Jagir ?" He then moved forward in the direction of Dilerkhan and again started attacking his soldiers. Dilerkhan who was seated in the houdah on the elephants back, released an arrow which pierced Murarbaji's neck. Murarbaji fell to the ground. His followers lifted his dead body and took it back to



The Battle between Murarbaji Deshpande and Dilerkhan

the upper fort. 'What if one Murarbaji is fallen ! We, too, are brave like him. We will fight with courage.' Saying so, they began to fight again without losing heart.

Shivaji heard the news with great sorrow. He knew that he could hold each one of his forts against the Moghul army for at least more than a year. But he was unwilling to do so at the cost of his men who would die in the attempt.

Treaty of Purandar : What could be done ? He was not strong enough to fight the powerful Moghuls. All his political skill was also of no avail. There was only one thing he could do. He decided on a temporary withdrawal from the fight. He would enter into a treaty with the Moghul Emperor. He went and saw Jaising. This was a very sensible and statesmanlike thing to do. He said to Jaising, "Mirza Raje, you are a Rajput. You can understand our suffering. The Emperor's campaigns have laid the country waste and people are in great misery. I have undertaken this task of establishing Swaraj so that people may be happy. You should join me in this uphill task. If you agree to lead us, myself and my Mavlas will be your trusted followers." Jaising was a shrewd diplomat. He persuaded Shivaji to sign



Shivaji Maharaj meets Mirza Raje Jaising.

a treaty of peace with the Emperor. Shivaji signed the treaty and according to its terms, twenty-three forts and a territory with a revenue of four lakh Hons (a gold coin) were to be handed over to the Emperor. The treaty of Purandar was signed in 1665.

After the treaty was signed, Jaising suggested to Shivaji that he should go to Agra and see the Emperor. He also guaranteed Shivaji's safe return. Shivaji thought over the suggestion. He knew that the Emperor could not be trusted. He had proved treacherous to his own brothers. But, in the end, Shivaji decided to take the risk and face the situation as cautiously as he could. He informed Jaising that he was willing to go to Agra to meet the Emperor.

EXERCISES

1. Fill in the blanks :

(a) ..... was a great centre of trade in the Moghul empire.

(Pune, Surat, Delhi)

(b) ..... was in charge of the fort of Purandar.

(Baji Prabhu, Tanaji, Murarbaji)

2. Write the answer in one sentence.

(a) Why did Shivaji carry out a raid on Surat ?

(b) Why did Dilerkhan lay siege to the Purandar fort ?

(c) Why did Shivaji enter into a treaty with the Moghul Emperor ?

(d) According to the treaty of Purandar, what territory was to be handed over to the Moghuls ?

3. Write the answer in two or three sentences.

(a) What did Dilerkhan say to Murarbaji on seeing his valour ?

(b) What did Murarbaji say in return ?

4. Complete these names from the lesson with the help of the given first letters.

(a) Au .....
(b) Pu .....
(c) Mu .....
(d) Ja .....
(e) Di .....

Activity

Arrange a trip to visit a fort nearby. Obtain some information about it from your teachers.